

Addicted to that rush

As a technology savvy father, my son has always had technology around him. From birth he would stare at his baby monitor, or fall asleep to the lullabies being played softly on the bluetooth speaker by his bed. As soon as he could sit up and grasp, he started playing with whatever smartphone happened to be lying nearby. Then he discovered the office iPad... I have sheepishly had to ask Jayesh for permission to keep the old iPad 3 for good, because my son is convinced it belongs to him. He's got a pretty mean right hook in store for anyone who touches it when he wants it, and failing that, he has his secret weapons – his teeth.

However, what really strikes me is his fascination for some games. There's this game called My Talking Tom, which is basically one of those typical corny virtual pet games, where you feed and bathe and put a cat to sleep as it grows older, and then you buy outfits, and poke it in the stomach or slap it and step on its tail if you're a mean kid – the type who experiments with magnifying glasses and ants...you know, the sadistic kids... they usually grow up to be dentists...

Anyway, my son doesn't care about the cat, or feeding it, or slapping it, or dressing it up, or anything at all actually. What he cares about is one of the mini games that you're expected to play to earn coins. A simple driving game, where you swipe a car left and right to avoid obstacles on the road. Lucas is addicted to that mini game, despite not even playing it. He just loves watching me play it. He knows when I'm close to breaking the old high score too, and his body tenses and he gets excitable.

I remember being as addicted to many games in a similar way. I spent days on end bettering my own personal best in the Long Jump mini games of Crashday. I did so well that I broke the supposed "world records" for those games. I had the same addiction for another game that the team here was playing, a rather simple game called ZigZag by Ketchapp. I spent countless hours improving my personal best on that too.

This got me thinking: What is it about games that makes them equally addictive to a two-year-old child and this 38-year-old baby? If I didn't have the smidgen of self-respect I'm left with, I'm sure I'd throw a fiercer tantrum than my son does when you take his iPad away. I

hated putting my phone down when I felt I was close to improving my personal best scores. I'd feel incomplete if I didn't play at least for two hours a day, especially as I inched closer to the 1,000 score mark... I also realised that I wasn't even competing with others. I was competing only with myself and attempting to improve my own high score.

It's not always competitiveness that gets us addicted. Facebook is really just a cross between a college canteen conversation and voyeurism. It's like sitting around the college canteen over-hearing interesting conversations, juicy gossip, while chatting with your friends about mutual interests, whilst you watch that guy/girl you secretly like out of the corner of your eye.

On the other hand, YouTube addiction is pretty much the same as a TV addiction. Doesn't matter whether you're watching female wrestling or FashionTV, or some video on YouTube of girls in bikinis or some bodybuilding competition, we know what you're really watching all that for... The same applies to watching stand-up comedy, scientific documentaries or anything under the sun...the bottom line is that you're getting your fix.

There's no point complaining about it like an old fogey either, because technology is here to stay, and if you don't keep up with the times, you're a fossil who just can't survive. Like technology, addictions are also here to stay. We've evolved into a species that expects (and usually gets) instant gratification, and that's not necessarily a bad thing. We've written about the evils of technology in the past; however, I think it's now time to embrace the changes.

Education is the first place that needs to change. Gamify it and more and more kids will be interested in learning. Let them compete with themselves, let them try and break their own high scores. The traditional multi-player world that is life will anyway keep the competitive spirit alive. That's just the start. How many more areas could benefit from just embracing addictions? Write in and share some suggestions with me. 



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